Setting up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring The Platform Architecture and Interface

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Introduction

Zoho Creator is a low-code platform meant for building business applications with very little hand-written code. Rather than coding an application from the ground up, a developer designs forms to collect data, reports to present it, and pages to lay out dashboards, while the platform takes care of the underlying database, interface and hosting on its own. Logic that the visual builder cannot express is added separately using Deluge, Zoho's built-in scripting language.

The admin console mirrors the natural life cycle of an application through three groups of modules. Develop houses the tools used to construct an application. Deploy houses the tools used to move a finished application out to its intended audience. Manage houses the administrative controls that decide who can use the applications, how access is secured, and how the account is billed. Keeping these three concerns apart makes the platform simpler to run as a team, since building, releasing and administering each have their own dedicated screen.

Zoho Creator Architecture

Looking past the admin console's own DEVELOP / DEPLOY / MANAGE grouping, Zoho Creator's underlying technical architecture can be described as seven layers, each responsible for a distinct concern in taking an application from a user's screen down to stored data and back. The diagram below summarises this layered architecture.

Layer	Role
01 — Access Layer	Provides multiple access channels through which an application is reached — web browsers, mobile apps, portals, and APIs.
02 — Presentation Layer	The Forms, Reports, and Pages that end users actually see and interact with when using an application.
03 — Application & Logic Layer	Runs the application's business logic through Workflows, Deluge scripting, integrations, and automation services.
04 — Data Layer	Stores application data securely using cloud databases, file storage, and scheduled backups.
05 — Governance & Security	Controls who can do what — user roles, permissions, authentication methods, and organizational policies.

Layer	Role
06 — Deployment & Lifecycle	Moves an application safely from build to release — staging, production deployment, version management, and publishing.
07 — Monitoring & Administration	Keeps the account running smoothly after release — analytics, operational monitoring, billing, and administration.

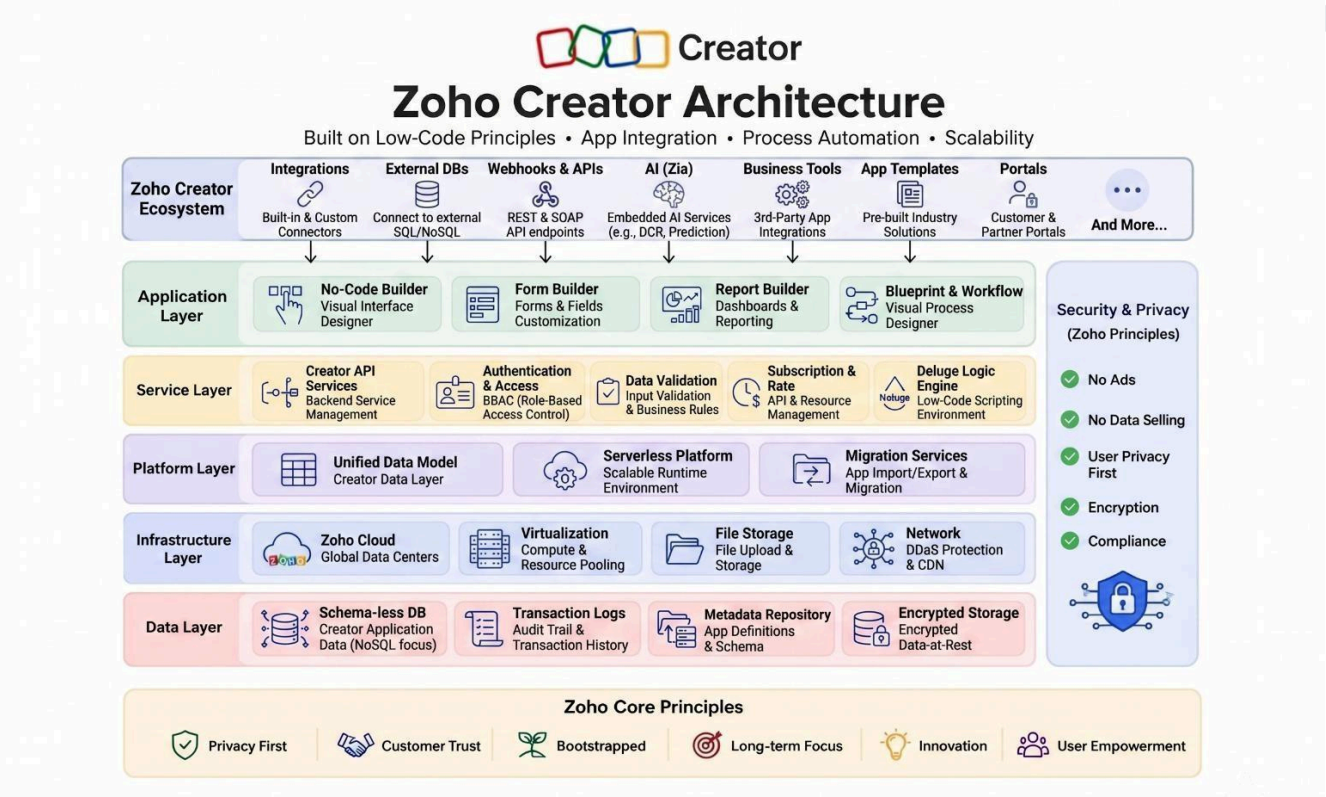


Figure 0: Zoho Creator architecture

Zoho Creator Console

Before walking through each screen individually, it helps to see how the Zoho Creator console itself is organized. Every module explored in this report lives inside one of three functional groups in the left-hand navigation: DEVELOP, DEPLOY, and MANAGE. The diagram below maps out this structure exactly as it appears in the console.

Category	Modules
DEVELOP	Applications, Microservices
DEPLOY	Environments, Mobile, Portal
MANAGE	Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing

The DEVELOP group is where applications originate: Applications is the home dashboard listing every app in the account, and Microservices provides modular components for connecting to third-party services and AI. The DEPLOY group governs how a finished app reaches its audience: Environments (Stage/Production) control safe release, Mobile handles app distribution to phones and tablets, and Portal opens a self-service gateway for external customers and partners.

The MANAGE group covers everything needed to administer the account as it grows: Users (accounts and roles), Organization (company profile and branding), Governance (security policies and authentication), Metrics (usage analytics), Operations (backup, audit, integrations, and more), and Billing (subscription and plan usage). The eleven screenshots that follow correspond one-to-one with these eleven modules, in the order they appear in the console's sidebar.

1. DEVELOP

The Develop group contains everything needed to build the application itself, along with any reusable back-end services it depends on.

1.A Applications

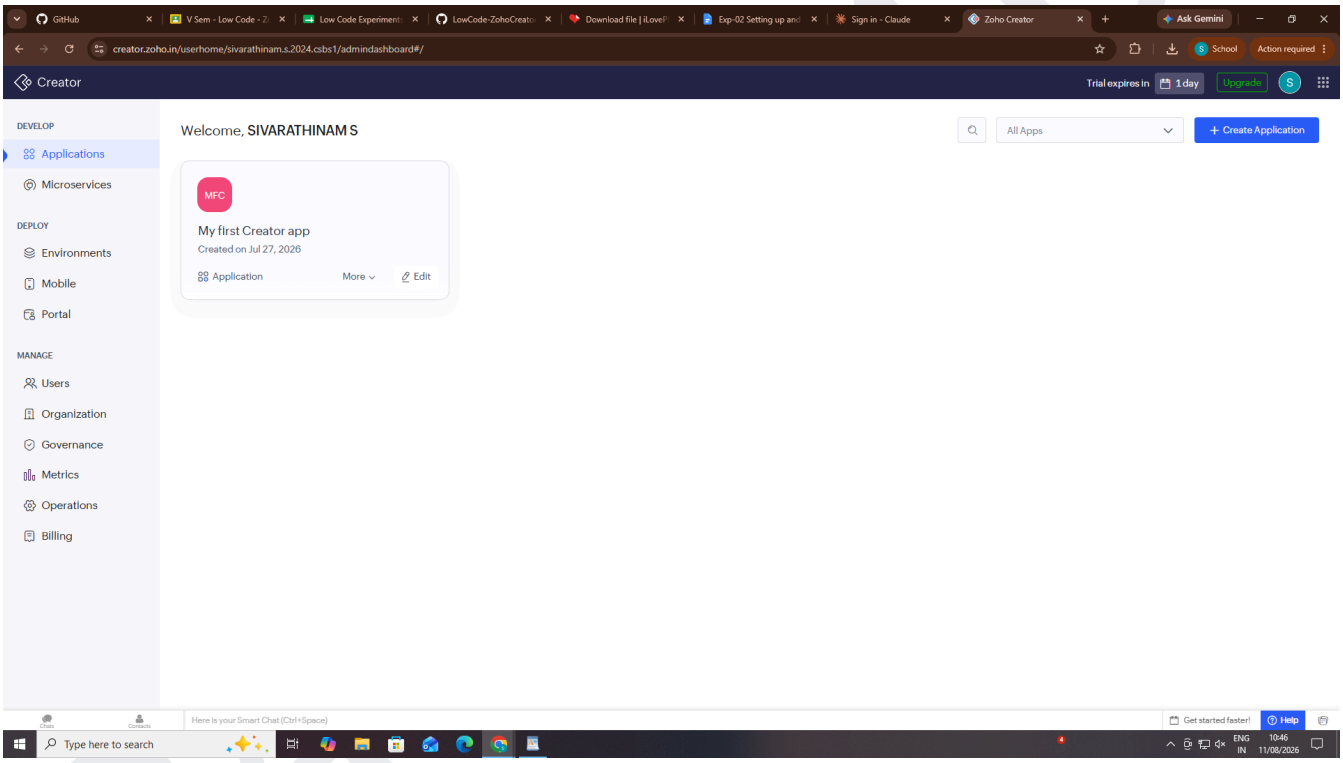


Fig. 1 — Applications module showing the sample application created for this experiment

Applications is the landing screen and main workspace of Zoho Creator. Every application under the account appears here as a card carrying its name, icon and creation date.

- Create Application — starts a new app from scratch, from a marketplace template, or by importing a spreadsheet.
- Edit — opens the application builder, where forms, reports, pages and Deluge workflows are put together.
- More — offers options such as rename, duplicate, share, export and delete for the selected application.
- All Apps filter and search — helps locate a particular application once several exist in the account.

1.B Microservices

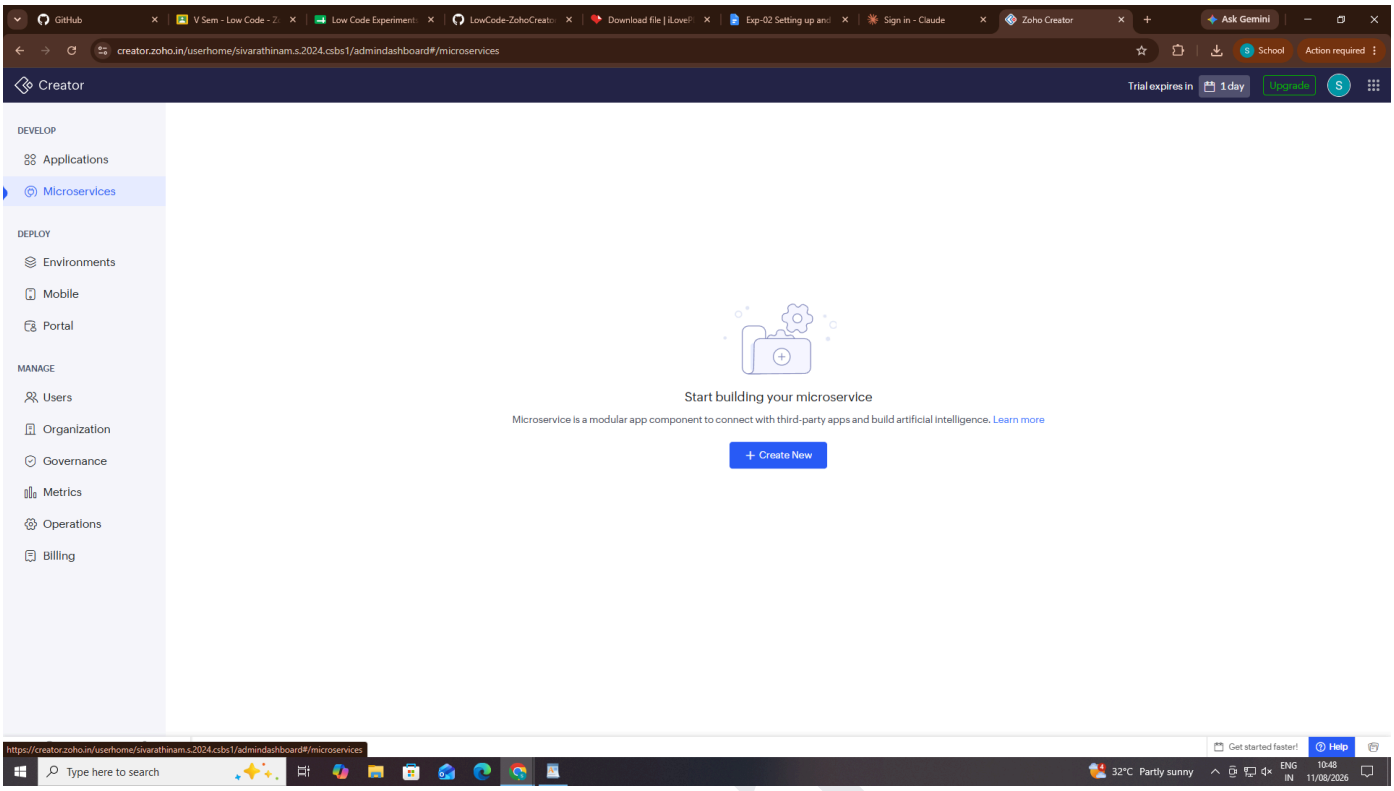


Fig. 2 — Microservices module before any microservice has been created

Microservices lets independent, reusable back-end services be written and hosted inside the Creator environment itself. Rather than repeating the same logic across several applications, a single piece of functionality — say, a tax calculation, a validation check, or a call to an external API — can be written once and then invoked by any application in the account through an endpoint. This keeps individual applications lighter and avoids duplicated code. As no microservice had been created at the time of the experiment, the screen shows the empty state with a Create New button.

- Create New — starts building a microservice from scratch.
- Provides a reusable endpoint that any application in the account can call.
- Keeps shared logic (validations, calculations, third-party calls) in one place instead of duplicating it per app.
- Learn more — links to platform documentation on microservices.

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2. DEPLOY

The Deploy group governs how a completed application actually reaches its users — through a staged release pipeline, on mobile devices, or through an external self-service gateway.

2.A Environments

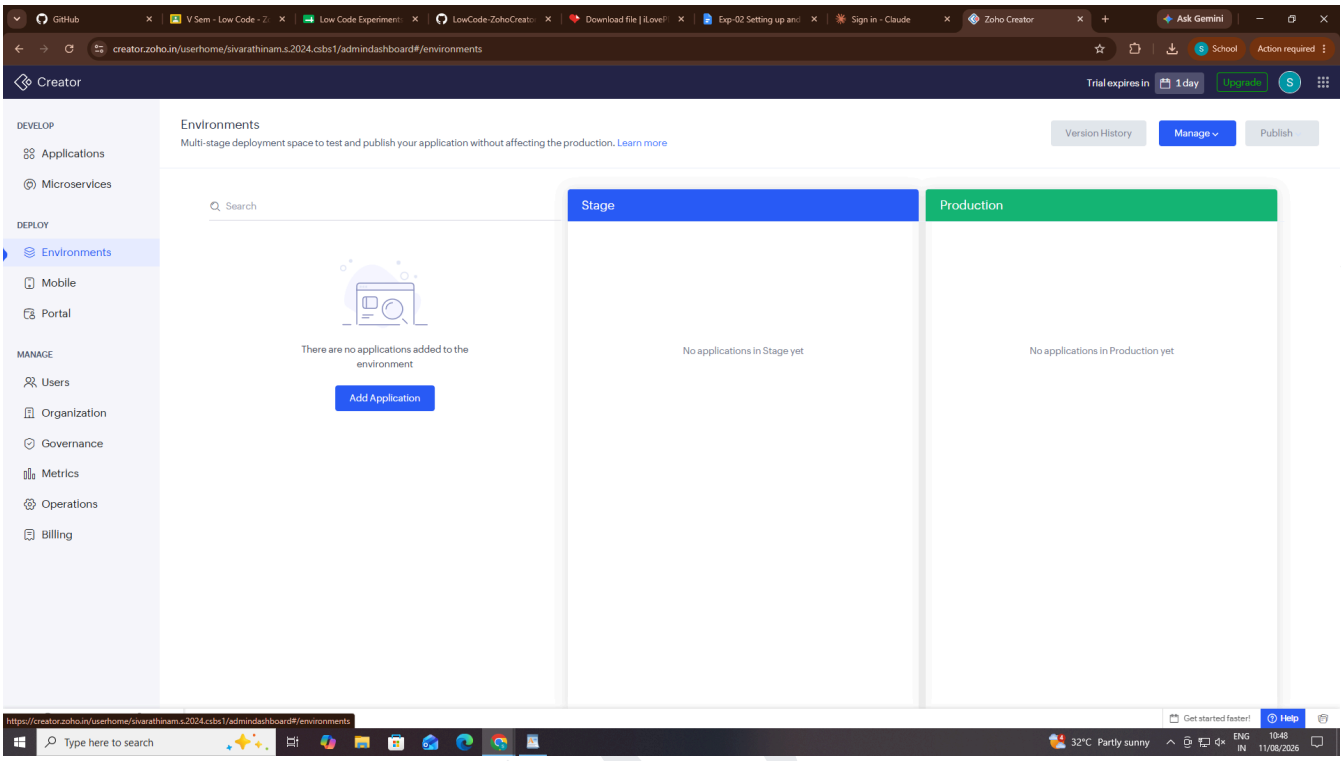


Fig. 3 — Environments module showing the Stage and Production columns

Environments provides a staged deployment space so that an application can be tested and released without disturbing the copy that live users depend on. The console presents Stage and Production as parallel columns representing successive points in the release pipeline:

Stage	Purpose
Development	The private working copy where the developer makes and tests changes before they go any further.
Stage	A rehearsal copy that mirrors production, used to verify a change is safe before it is released.
Production	The live copy that real end users work with.

- Publish — promotes an application from one stage to the next.
- Version History — lists earlier published versions and allows a rollback if a release turns out to be faulty.
- Manage — used to configure the pipeline and choose which applications take part in it.

In the screenshot, the Stage and Production columns are both empty, since the sample application had not yet been added to the deployment pipeline.

2.B Mobile

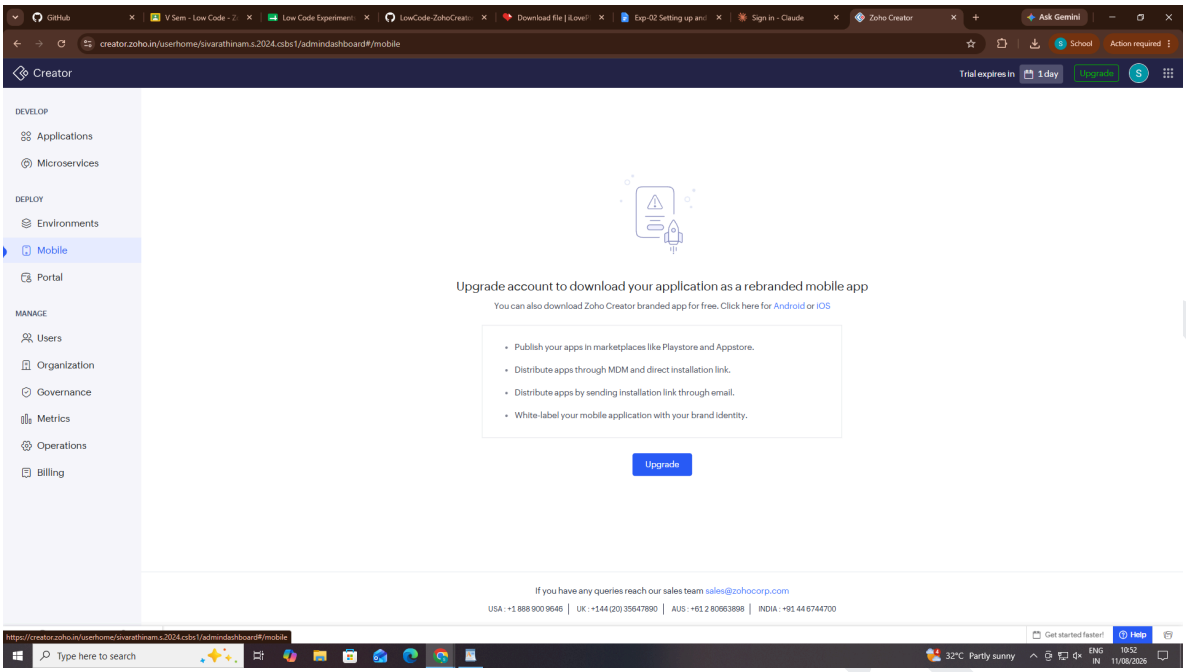


Fig. 4 — Mobile module showing distribution options for the account

The Mobile module controls how an application behaves on smartphones and tablets. Zoho Creator applications are automatically reachable through the Zoho Creator mobile app; upgrading the account unlocks a rebranded, white-labeled mobile app carrying the organisation's own identity instead of Zoho's.

- Publish apps to marketplaces such as the Play Store and App Store.
- Distribute apps through Mobile Device Management (MDM) or a direct installation link.
- Send installation links to users by e-mail.
- White-label the mobile application with the organisation's own brand identity (paid upgrade).

2.C Portal

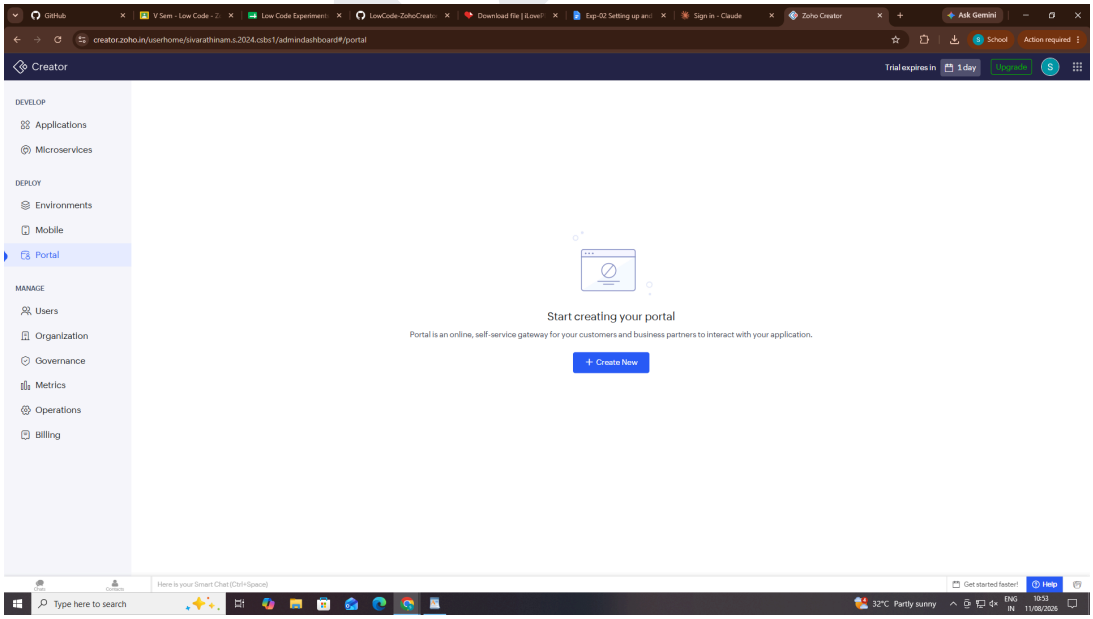


Fig. 5 — Portal module before any portal has been created

A Portal is a self-service gateway that lets customers or business partners work with an application without being a licensed user of the Creator account — for instance, a customer who logs in only to raise a request or check an order, while internal staff continue to use the full application. Since portal users are external to the account, they are counted and priced on a separate basis from internal users. As no portal existed at the time of the experiment, the screen shows the empty state with a Create New button.

- Create New — starts building a self-service portal for external users.
- Keeps external (portal) access separate from internal, licensed user access.
- Lets customers/partners submit requests or view their own records without full account access.

3. MANAGE

The Manage group holds the administrative side of the account — who its users are, how the organisation is identified, how access is secured, and how the subscription is billed.

3.A Users

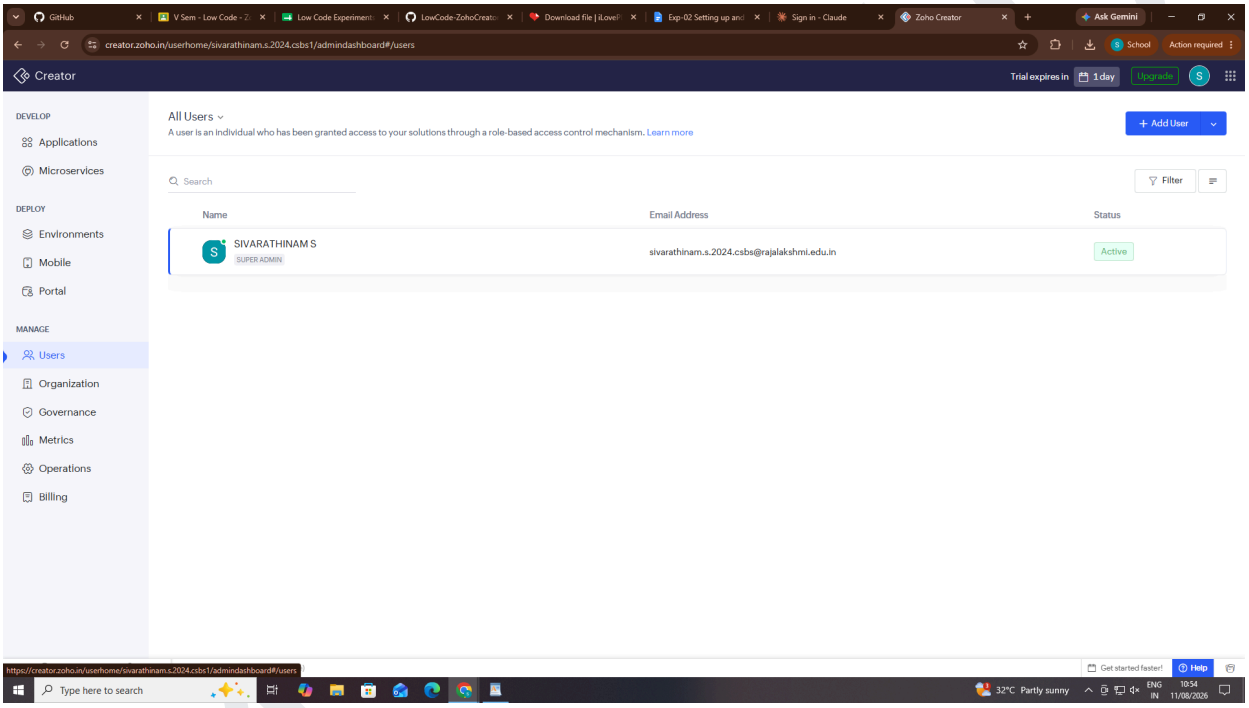


Fig. 6 — Users module listing the Super Admin of the account

The Users module manages everyone who has been given access to the account's applications through role-based access control. Each entry shows a name, e-mail address and status. The screenshot lists a single user, , marked SUPER ADMIN with an Active status — the owner who created the organisation.

- Add User — invites a new member by e-mail and assigns a role that decides what that member can access.
- Status — shows whether an invited user is Active or still awaiting confirmation of the invite.
- Filter and Search — helps locate users by role, status or name once an organisation has many members. Role-based access control ties permissions to a role rather than to a person, so a member gets the right level of access simply by being placed in the appropriate role.

3.B Organization

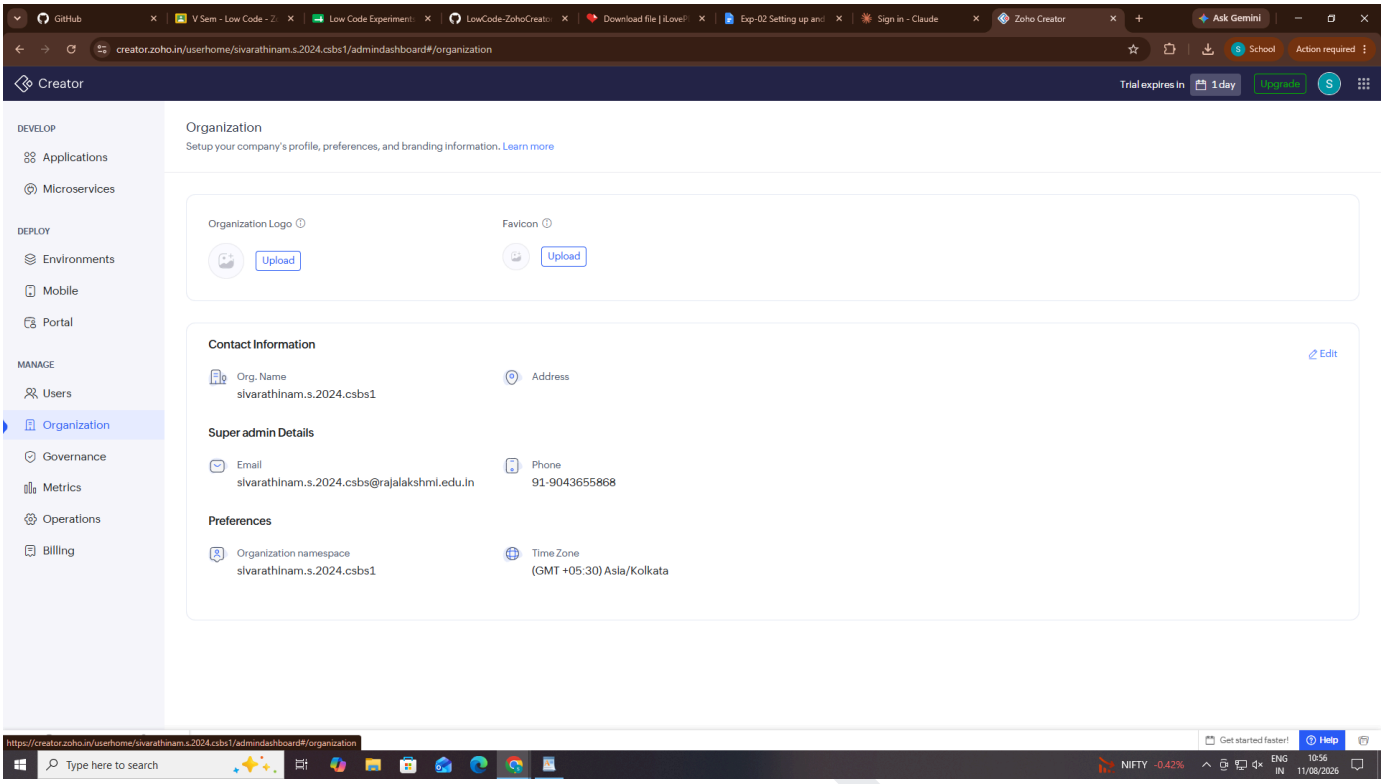


Fig. 7 — Organization module showing profile, admin details and preferences

The Organization module holds the identity, branding and default preferences of the account — the one place where information shared across every application in the account is defined.

Setting	Purpose
Organization Logo / Favicon	Branding images that would be carried across the applications and portals built under the account.
Contact Information	The registered organisation name and address.
Super Admin Details	The e-mail address and phone number of the account owner, used for account recovery and critical alerts.
Organization Namespace	A unique identifier that becomes part of the URL of every application created under the account.
Time Zone	The default time zone applied to timestamps and scheduled workflows — set to (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata for this account.

3.C Governance

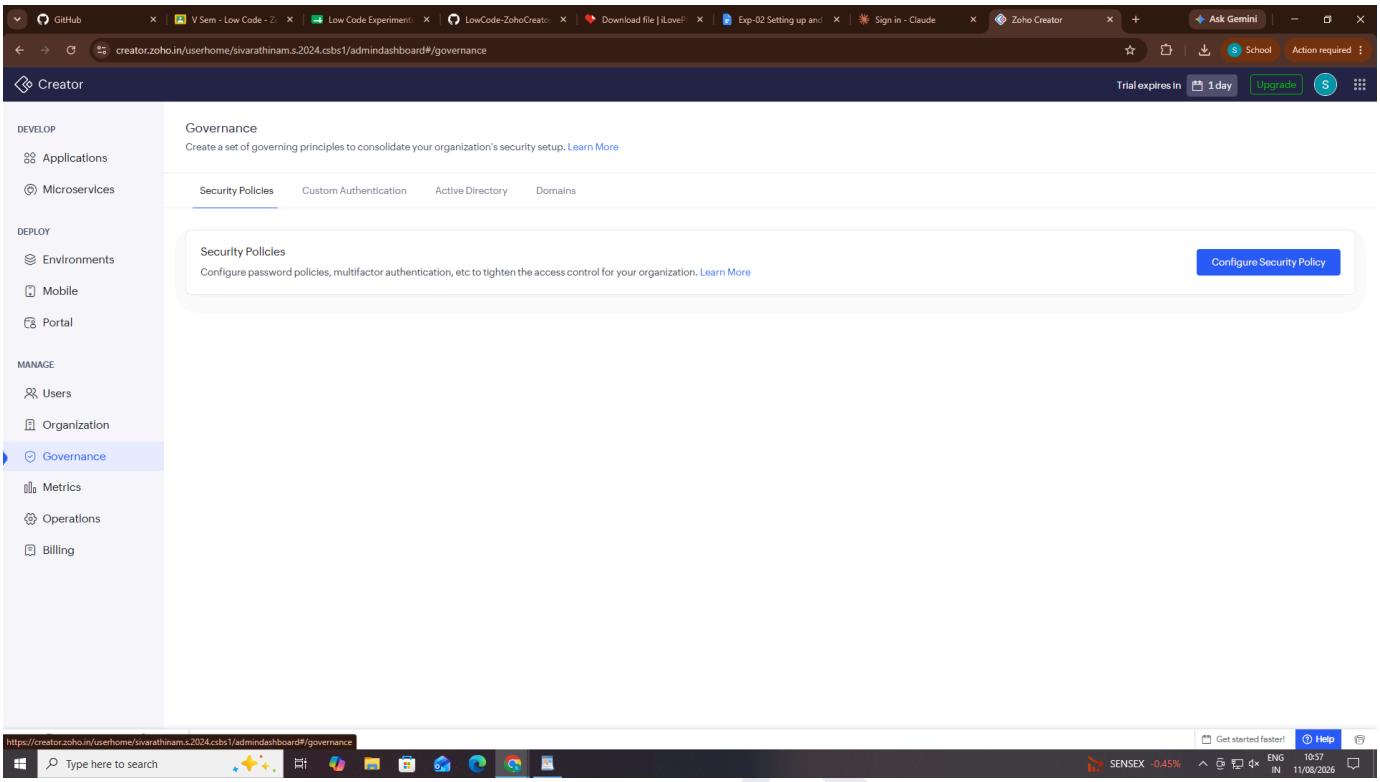


Fig. 8 — Governance module with its four configuration tabs

Governance brings together a set of principles that consolidate the security posture of the organisation, spread across four tabs:

Tab	Function
Security Policies	Sets password-strength rules, password expiry and multi-factor authentication for the account.
Custom Authentication	Lets users sign in through an external identity provider, such as a single sign-on service, instead of a Zoho account.
Active Directory	Synchronises users and groups from a corporate Active Directory so access follows the existing directory structure.
Domains	Registers and verifies a custom domain so applications can be hosted on the organisation's own address instead of a default Zoho URL.

3.D Metrics

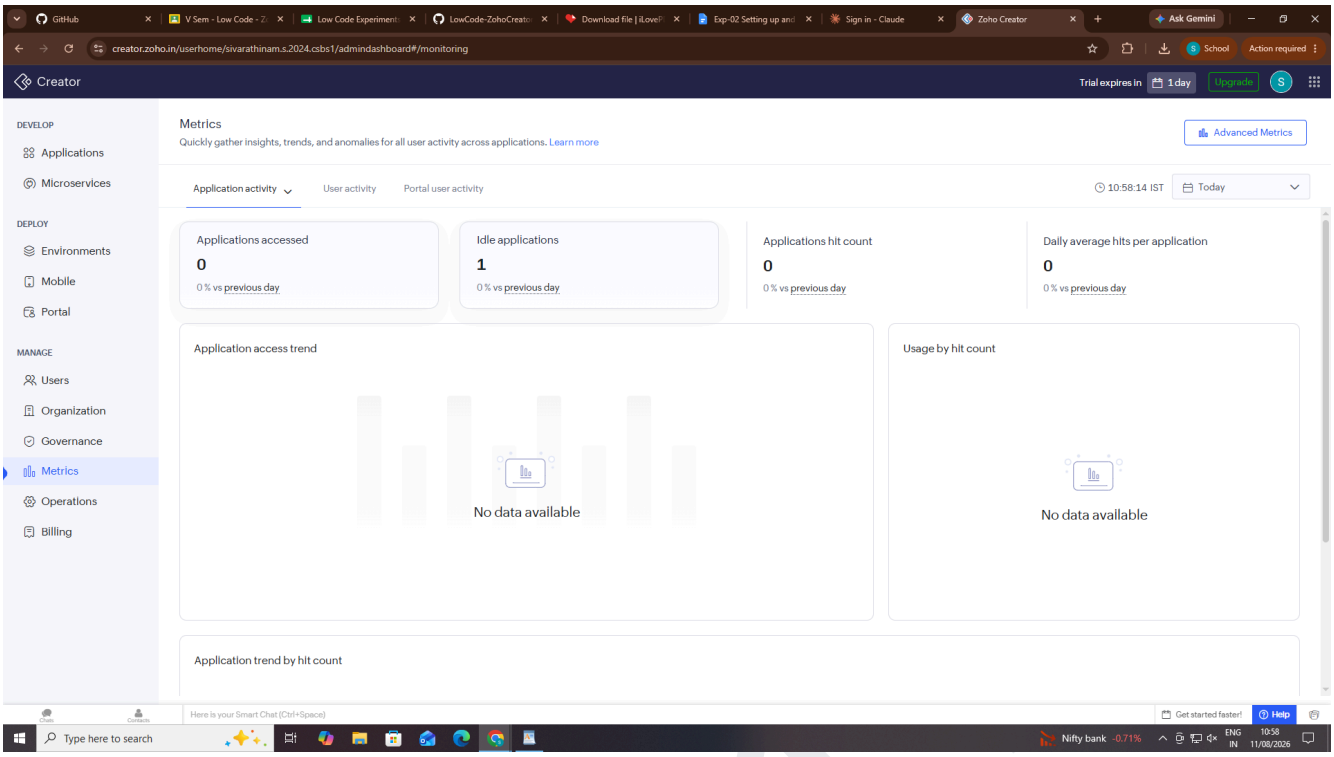


Fig. 9 — Metrics module showing application activity for the account

The Metrics module presents usage analytics for the account, split across Application activity, User activity and Portal user activity tabs. Summary cards track Applications Accessed, Idle Applications, Applications Hit Count and Daily Average Hits per Application, backed by trend charts ("Application access trend" and "Usage by hit count"). This helps an administrator notice when the account is nearing a threshold and may need an upgrade. Since the account is newly created, all figures currently read zero or "No data available."

- Track application, user and portal activity separately, by tab.
- Monitor applications accessed and idle applications over a selected time range.
- View application hit counts and daily average usage.
- Access Advanced Metrics for deeper, longer-range analysis.

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3.E Operations

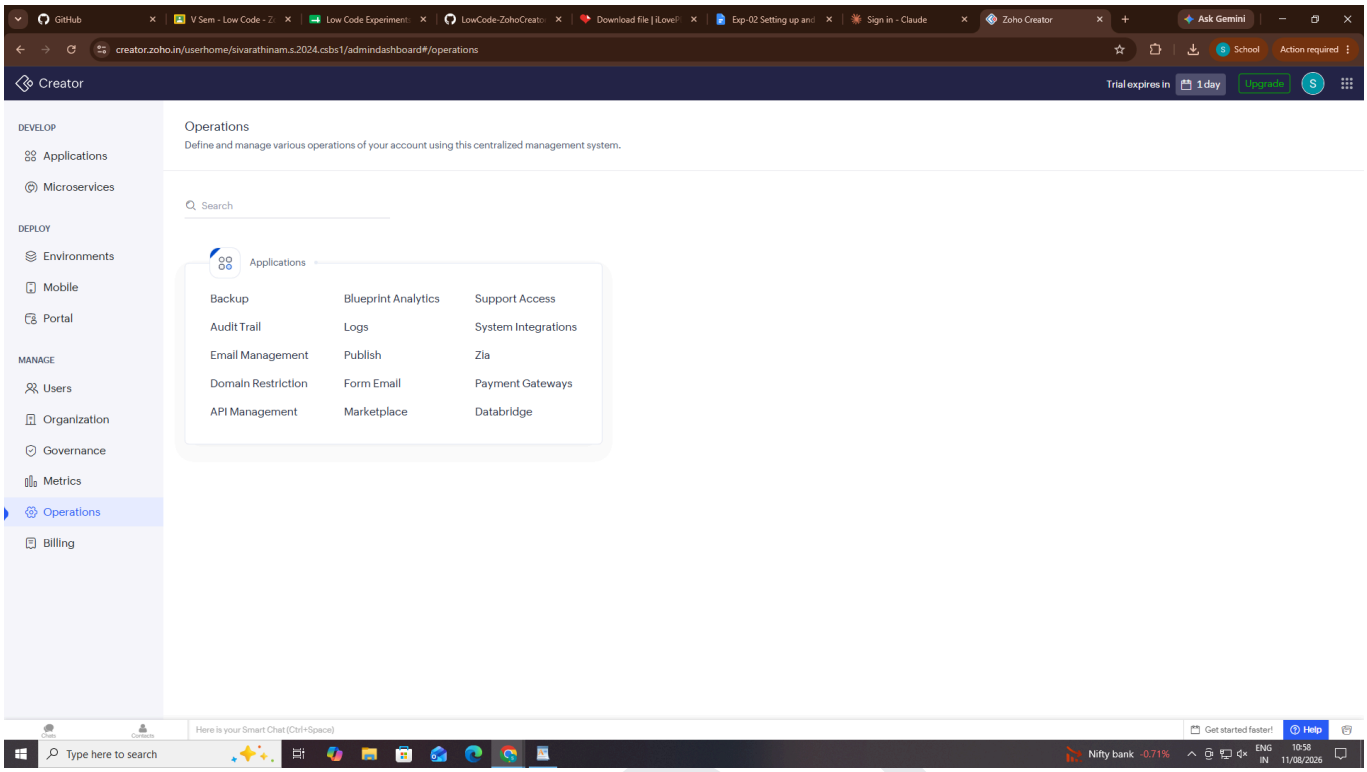


Fig. 10 — Operations module listing the account-level operational tools

Operations is a single management screen through which the account's day-to-day operational tools are defined and controlled. All the tools sit under an Applications panel and can be located with the search box:

Tool	Function
Backup	Takes a copy of application data and schema so it can be restored after accidental loss.
Audit Trail	Logs who carried out which action and when, for accountability and compliance.
Email Management	Configures the sender addresses and templates used for application notifications.
Domain Restriction	Restricts sign-in to users whose e-mail address belongs to an approved domain.
API Management	Generates and controls the API keys and endpoints used by external systems.
Blueprint Analytics	Reports on the performance of Blueprints, the visual business-process flows, and flags stages where records stall.
Logs	Displays system and script execution logs used to trace errors.
Publish	Controls how applications and individual components are exposed publicly.
Form Email	Allows records to be created in an application directly from an incoming e-mail.
Marketplace	Offers ready-made templates and extensions that can be installed into the account.

Support Access	Temporarily grants the Zoho support team permission to view the account while resolving an issue.
System Integrations	Connects Creator with other Zoho products and third-party applications.

Tool	Function
Zia	Zoho's AI assistant, offering prediction, data enrichment and conversational access to application data.
Payment Gateways	Configures payment providers so forms can accept payments.
Databridge	Synchronises data between Creator and an on-premises or external database.

3.F Billing

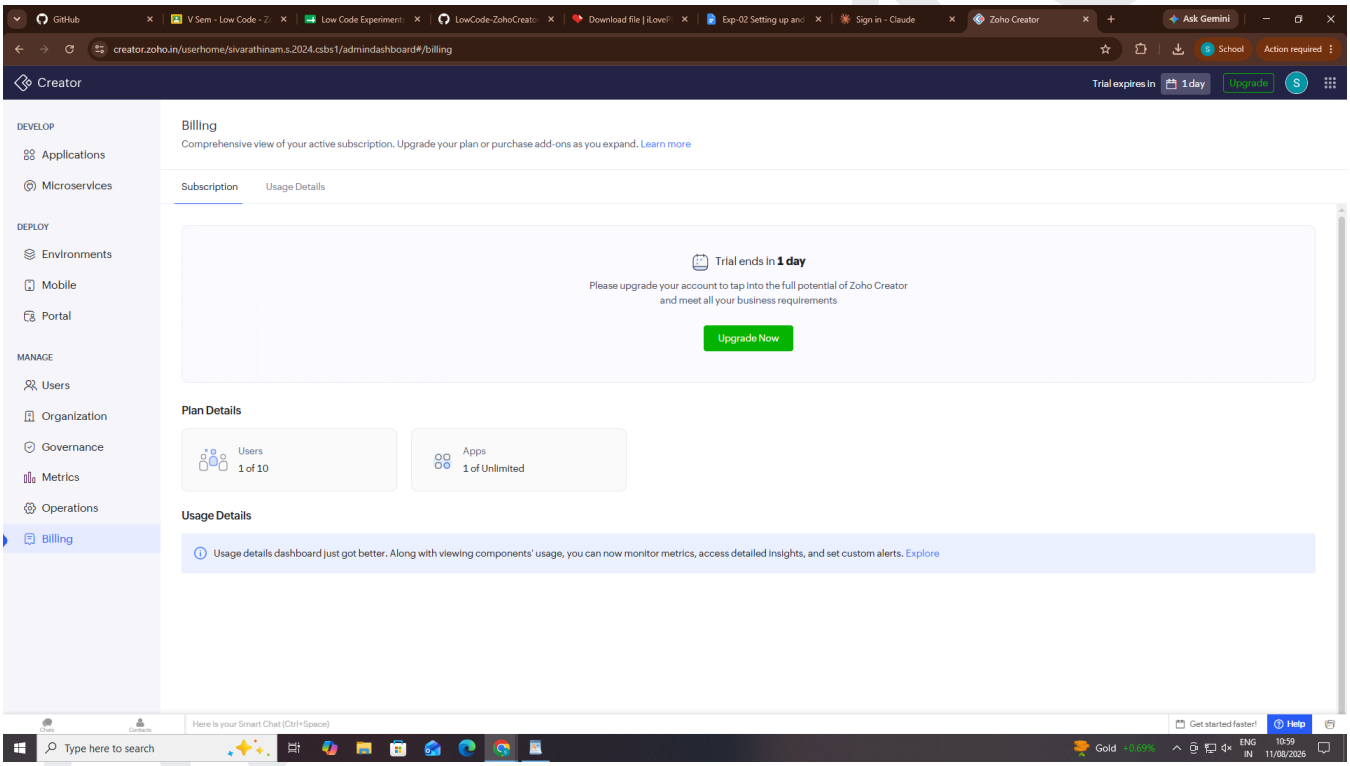


Fig. 11 — Billing module showing trial status, plan details and usage

The Billing module gives a full view of the active subscription and is where the plan is upgraded or add-ons are bought. It is split into a Subscription tab and a Usage Details tab.

- Trial status — the banner shows the trial ending in 15 days, with an Upgrade Now button to move to a paid subscription.
- Plan Details — shows consumption against the plan's entitlement; this account has used 1 of 10 permitted users and 1 of an unlimited number of applications.
- Usage Details — tracks component-level usage, offers deeper insight, and lets custom alerts be set before a limit is reached.

Conclusion

This experiment shows that Zoho Creator splits the full application life cycle into three clearly separated groups. Develop supplies the building tools — Applications for the app itself and Microservices for reusable back-end logic. Deploy supplies the release tools — Environments for a staged release pipeline, Mobile for delivery on handheld devices, and Portal for controlled access by outside customers and partners. Manage supplies the administrative tools — Users for role-based access, Organization for identity and branding, Governance for security policy, Metrics for usage analytics, Operations for backups, logs, integrations and other routine controls, and Billing for the subscription.

This layout illustrates the central benefit of a low-code platform: the developer's attention stays on business logic, while the platform supplies the database, hosting, access control, deployment pipeline and monitoring as ready-made, configurable services instead of code that has to be written and maintained by hand.

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